converts through manumission, or the freeing of slaves. However, in practice the second half of the Koran's well-known injunction to set free the bonds of the captive unbelievers[5] was frequently overlooked as slavery became increasingly institutionalised. Christian Europe has been rightly castigated for the genocidal West African slave trade into the Americas and West Indies but the scale of slavery under Islam bears comparison, even if it is far less well documented. In the Indian context, the enslavement of *dhimmi*s, or non-Muslims, progressed from being a weapon of war to an essential feature of the economy of the Delhi Sultanates and the so-called Slave Dynasty.[6]

In South India, the Deccan Sultanates of Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Berar, Golconda and Bidar were all similarly dependent on labour forces of enslaved *dhimmi*s, a famous example being Malik Ambar, an Ethiopian slave purchased in the slave-market of Baghdad who rose to become commander of the army of the Sultan of Bijapur before switching sides to become the de facto ruler of what later became the city of Aurangabad. I have given these Sultanates scant recognition in these pages, but it should be noted that once they had been secured an extraordinarily cosmopolitan and pluralist culture tended to flourish within their borders, leaving their non-Muslim subjects free to practise their religion provided they paid the *jizya* infidel poll tax.[7]

Emperor Akbar (1542–1605) sought to prohibit the enslavement of Hindus conquered in the many wars fought under his authority, but his successors resumed the practice, most notably his great-grandson Aurangzeb, who codified it in his *Fatawa-e-Alamgiri*, the stifling impact of which I explore later in this chapter.

The advance of this more martial Islam from North India into the South meant that by the time the Portuguese began their depredations at the start of the sixteenth century the